eight old executive orders and a legislation that had included 114 groups—106 of them Muslim—among the Other Backward Classes (OBCs). The wholesale manner of their inclusion, in 2010 and 2012, suggested "the said community has been treated as a commodity for political ends", the court said, acidly. Modi lost no time to cite it and say "vote bank politics...is crossing every limit". Whether infused with religion or not, caste reservation has become the directive principle of this election so emphatically that it looks destined to endure beyond June 4. The ghost at India's electoral banquet that refuses to leave.

THE OPPOSITION STRIKES FIRST

Paradoxically, the axis tilted just when Modi was soaring into orbit, flowing from his assertion that the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) would cross 400 seats in the Lok Sabha. Such a majority would constitute near-sovereign levels of functional power. Repeated in incantatory tones, it also took on a certain symbolic potency. This flight of aspiration was borne aloft by a series of events: three Hindi heartland assembly election wins, the ceremony at Ayodhya that consummated a key Hindutva dream, and a run of dazzling tactical play that lassoed in key Opposition figures. One of them was Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar, the original engineering draughtsman for a second-generation model of Mandal. In 2022, all eyes had been on the live demo he put up of his consummate skills at political gymnastics while he executed another one of his pirouettes—this time, away from the BJP and towards his old frenemy, the RJD. Slowly, he also began giving himself a leading role in his own political script and production, the INDIA bloc. Fewer people took note of the vastly more seminal idea he was seeding: increasing reservations, particularly for the OBCs. On October 2, 2023, a date chosen with finesse, Nitish released the findings of the Bihar caste survey—the first time an official caste count was being made public anywhere in India since 1931. It confirmed a widely held surmise: the OBCs constituted 63.14 per cent of Bihar's population. The statistical injustice of the existing reservation space hemming them into a 27 per cent quota—because of the judicial ceiling of 50 per cent on overall quotas—lay there in plain sight, arguing its own case. Soon, the INDIA bloc, too, adopted the idea of expanded reservations as its raison d'etre, and it loomed menacingly before the BJP as a rival narrative. But with Nitish seduced to rejoin the BJP, the threat appeared conclusively neutralised. Or so it seemed.

The storm began again somewhat innocuously. A week before the dates for General Election 2024 were announced, Anantkumar Hegde, a BJP MP and regular stormtrooper from Karnataka, said getting 400-plus seats was a necessity for the BJP-led NDA because "the Constitution has to be amended...it cannot be done without a two-thirds majority". Enough for the Opposition to pounce on the remark and amplify it multifold. The campaign, just picking up then, changed colour and tenor. A remark by Modi in February—giving notice to "even bigger decisions" in his third term—was now reinterpreted by the Opposition as bristling with intent. The INDIA bloc, led by the Congress, spread the word that the Modi government was out to abolish reservations based on caste as it never sat well ideologically with the old saffron notion of monolithic Hindu-



"GOVERNMENTS DID NOT ASK A QUESTION ON CASTE IN THE CENSUS FROM 1951 TO 2011. THEN THE DEMAND AROSE. HAD WE BEEN IN POWER, WE'D HAVE INCLUDED IT IN THE 2021 CENSUS"

P. CHIDAMBARAM
Senior Congress Leader

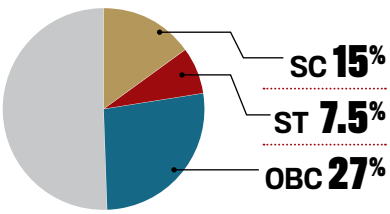
OBC RIDDLE

There has been no caste census since 1931, which estimated OBCs to be 52% of population. This is what the Mandal Commission also used. Sociologists say the numbers could be much higher—the Bihar survey found OBCs to be 63% in the state

MANDAL COMMISSION 1980
52%

BIHAR CASTE SURVEY 2023
63%
Only for Bihar

CASTE QUOTA PIE



In case of direct recruitment on all India basis by open competition. The SC presently caps total SC-ST-OBC reservation at 50%

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